Teaching AI agents how to do the job



How agents learn your unique workflows

Laura Solarz · BUS/FIN 241A · Source: “What AI Agent Skills Are and How They Work” IBM Technology, Martin Keen (2026)

LLMs know facts, not your procedures

47 steps to produce one compliant report

Prompt each step every time

Or it guesses

A skill is a folder that loads in layers

SKILL.md: name + description

Tier 1 · required · always loaded · the trigger

SKILL.md: instructions

Tier 2 · loaded when a request matches

Optional: scripts/ · references/ · assets/

Tier 3 · only when needed

Progressive disclosure

more detail, loaded later



Four ways to give an agent knowledge

MCP

What it can reach

RAG

What it can look up

Fine-tuning

What's baked in

Skills

How to do the work

Skills are procedural memory



Semantic (facts) → RAG & knowledge bases

Episodic (experiences) → Conversation logs

Procedural (how-to) → **Skills**

Review before you install



- Prompt injection
- Tool poisoning
- Hidden malware

Vet publicly shared skills like any software dependency

Write the procedure once

Used when relevant · Loaded as needed

Open format, private content

~~47~~



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